BUSINESS PROCESS INNOVATION

Industry Visit Field Manual

A Self-Guided Framework for Students

Competency: Business Process Innovation

Student Name: _____

Organization Visited: _____

Industry Vertical: _____

Visit Dates: _____

Before You Begin: What This Visit Is Really About

You are not going on a field trip. You are not going to observe a business from a distance and write a summary of what you saw. What you are about to do is far more demanding — and far more valuable.

The purpose of this visit is to develop in you a rare combination of capabilities that very few professionals possess. By the end of this programme, you should be able to think like a business owner who understands every decision from the inside, analyse like a process consultant who has seen a hundred different businesses and knows where the hidden problems live, and build like an engineer who can translate observations into real, working solutions using modern tools and technology.

This document is your operational guide for the visit. It is structured, but it is not rigid. Different businesses will reveal different things in different orders. Your task is to ensure that by the time you leave the organization, you have covered every dimension described in this manual — not because a checklist told you to, but because you genuinely understood what you were looking for and why.

The Core Question You Must Answer

By the end of visit, you must be able to answer this one question with complete clarity:

"If I were the owner of this business, what are the three most important changes I would make — and exactly how would I implement them?"

Everything in this manual is designed to give you the depth of understanding needed to answer that question honestly and specifically.

The 4-Pillar Documentation Standard

Before you enter the organization, you must internalize this standard. It applies to every process, every function, and every activity you observe throughout the entire visit. When you study anything — a task, a system, a workflow, a communication practice — you must capture four specific things.

Current State (What)	The Friction (Ouch)	The Hidden Solution (Idea)	The Barrier (Why Not)
How is this currently done, step by step?	*What discomfort, inefficiency or risk does the person feel?*	*What does the stakeholder wish could be done differently?*	*What constraint stops the idea from being implemented?*

This is not a format to fill in at the end of the day. It is a lens through which you observe and interact in real time. Every time you sit with a stakeholder and ask about their work, you are looking for these four things. Do not leave a conversation until you have at least the first two pillars for every area discussed.

Why all four pillars matter

- The Current State tells you what exists.
- The Friction tells you where the real pain is.
- The Hidden Solution tells you what the person already wants — they often know the answer.
- The Barrier tells you why real change is hard and what your solution must overcome to actually work.

Rules of Engagement

These are not suggestions. They are the behaviours that separate a surface-level observer from a genuine business analyst.

Rule	What it means in practice
Observe first, ask later	Do not interrupt ongoing operations. Watch the process naturally. Note your questions and ask during a natural pause or break.
Never accept 'Everything is fine'	If a stakeholder says a process works perfectly, look deeper. Find the workarounds, the undocumented habits, the post-it notes on the screen.
Quantify every pain point	When someone says 'this is slow' or 'this is a problem,' always ask: How often? How long? What happens when it fails? Vague complaints are not insights.
Follow the Worst Day Rule	Ask every stakeholder: 'Walk me through the most chaotic or difficult day you have had recently. What exactly went wrong, and why?' This unlocks what normal conversation hides.
Collect ideas, not just problems	Many employees already know what would fix their situation. Your job is to surface those ideas. Ask explicitly: 'Have you ever thought of a better way to do this?'
Interview every level	The owner sees the business from one angle. A floor worker sees it from a completely different angle. Both are true. You need both.
Validate before concluding	Before you write a finding as a fact, share it with a stakeholder and ask if your understanding is correct. This prevents misinterpretation.

Stakeholder Interview Guide

You must interact with a minimum of five stakeholders representing different levels and roles. Do not limit yourself to whoever is most convenient. The most valuable insights often come from the people who are rarely asked for their opinion. Adapt your questions to the person's role and context.

Frontline Staff — Operators, Floor Workers, Clerks

- If you could change one thing about your daily routine to make your work less frustrating, what would that be?
- Show me how you do this task. Are there any unofficial steps you take because the standard way is too slow or doesn't work well?
- What part of your work feels like a waste of your time and skills?
- How often does this problem occur? What happens to your work when it does?
- Have you ever suggested a better way? What happened?

Mid-Level Management — Supervisors, Department Heads

- What is the one resource — time, information, equipment, or people — that you are constantly waiting for or running short of?
- What is an improvement idea you have had for a long time, but have not been able to implement due to lack of budget, time, or technical support?
- What goes wrong most frequently on the ground that the owner or senior management may not fully be aware of?
- Are there problems that your team has learned to live with, even though they know it is not the right way?

Executive Leadership — Owners, Directors, CEOs

- When operations are running smoothly, what is the underlying risk that still concerns you?
- When making critical business decisions, what specific data do you wish you had immediately available — on your phone, or at a glance?
- Which processes in this business are you most proud of, and which ones do you feel need the most improvement?
- If you had to describe the single biggest constraint on your growth right now, what would it be?

Vendors and External Stakeholders (where accessible)

- What problems do you face most often when dealing with this organization?

- Is there anything about how they communicate or place orders that creates difficulty for you?
- What would make your relationship with this business smoother and more efficient?

Before the Visit: Preparation

The quality of your visit depends entirely on how well you prepare. A student who arrives with no background understanding will spend half their time figuring out what the business does. A student who arrives prepared will spend that same time uncovering what no one else has noticed.

Select your organization thoughtfully

Choose a business where you have genuine access — through family, friends, or community connections — to the owner, managers, and floor-level employees. The depth of access matters more than the size or prestige of the organization. A small manufacturing unit where you can spend time on the production floor is far more valuable than a large company where you can only meet the PR manager.

You will visit four different business verticals across this programme. Each should be from a different industry so that you can begin to recognize patterns that are common across businesses, as well as differences that are specific to each sector. Consider businesses such as a hospital, a retail trader, an event management company, a transport operator, a manufacturer, or a service provider.

Conduct a basic background study

Before you arrive, spend time understanding the general nature of the industry. Research how businesses in this sector typically operate — what they produce or deliver, who their customers are, what their key processes look like, and what challenges are common in that industry. This does not need to be deep research. The goal is to ensure you are not starting from zero on Day 1. Write down what you know, and more importantly, write down what you do not yet know.

Introduce yourself correctly

When you meet the owner or manager for the first time, be clear about your purpose. Explain that you are a student studying business processes as part of your engineering programme. You are not conducting an audit, you are not judging the business, and you are not there to find fault. You are there to understand how the business works from the inside, so that you can develop the ability to support businesses like theirs with better systems and technology in the future. This framing builds trust and opens doors.

DAY 1

Orientation, Overview & The Big Picture

Day 1 is about building orientation. You are not expected to solve anything today. You are not expected to judge anything today. Your only task is to develop a genuine, complete understanding of what this business is, how it works at the highest level, and where the key pressure points seem to be. Observe more than you speak. Ask open questions. Take notes on everything, including the things that seem obvious.

Phase 1: Business Overview and End-to-End Flow

Your first task is to understand the business as a complete system — not department by department, but as a whole. What does this business exist to do? Who does it serve? How does value move through it from start to finish?

What to observe

- What product or service does this business provide, and what specific problem does it solve for its customers?
- Who are the primary customers? Are there different types of customers with different needs?
- How does the business make money? What is the core transaction that drives revenue?
- What are the main departments or functions in this organization? How do they relate to one another?

The Single Unit Trace — a mandatory first exercise

On Day 1, you must identify one real unit of work and trace its complete journey through the business. This could be one customer order, one patient visit, one service request, one booking, or one product being manufactured. It must be a real, current example — not a hypothetical.

Follow it physically and digitally from the moment the business first becomes aware of this customer or order, all the way through to the moment it is completed and delivered. At each stage, record the following:

- What is being done to the unit at this stage?
- Who is responsible for this step?
- What information or material does this step require to begin?
- How long does this step take? How long does the unit wait before this step begins?
- What does the unit look like when it leaves this step — what has changed?

This trace will become the foundation of your entire analysis. It shows you the bones of the business. Every inefficiency, every dependency, and every vulnerability you discover later in the visit will connect back to this map.

Questions to ask the owner or senior manager

- Can you walk me through what happens from the moment a customer contacts you to the moment you consider that job complete?
- How many people and departments does a typical order pass through?
- At what point in that journey do you feel the most uncertainty or the most risk?
- What is the single most important activity in your business — the one that, if it stopped, would affect everything else?

Phase 2: Routine Operations — Systems vs. Habits

Every business has two kinds of work: work that happens in response to customer demand, and work that must happen regardless of any specific order or customer. This second category — routine operational tasks — is where many businesses silently lose control.

What to investigate

- Identify the tasks that must happen every day, every week, and every month regardless of what orders are active.
- For each routine task, determine whether it is driven by a formal system — a written procedure, a software reminder, a scheduled calendar event — or whether it exists only in someone's memory.
- Determine who is responsible for each routine task. Is responsibility clearly assigned, or is it assumed?
- Identify what happens when a routine task is missed. Has this happened? What was the impact?

The dependency test

For every critical routine task, ask yourself and the stakeholders this question: if the person who currently does this task were unavailable for thirty days — due to illness, emergency, or departure — would the system continue to function, or would it collapse?

The answer to this question reveals one of the most important vulnerabilities in any business: the difference between a process that is institutionalized and a process that exists only in an individual's head. Document every case where the answer is 'it would collapse.'

Questions to ask

- What are the tasks your team must do every day, even when there are no new orders?
- Where are these tasks written down or tracked? Can you show me?
- Have you ever had a situation where something important was forgotten because the responsible person was absent? What happened?
- If you had to hand over your role to someone new tomorrow, how long would it take to train them, and what would they most likely get wrong?

Phase 3: First Round of Stakeholder Interactions

By mid-morning or early afternoon of Day 1, you should have enough context to begin structured conversations with different stakeholders. These are not casual conversations. They are disciplined interviews guided by the 4-Pillar Standard introduced at the beginning of this manual.

For every area you discuss with a stakeholder, you are looking for all four pillars: what is currently done, where the friction is, what idea the person already has, and what prevents that idea from being implemented.

Sequence of interactions on Day 1

- Begin with the owner or senior manager to get the strategic overview. Understand the business's purpose, aspirations, and the problems that concern them most.
- Move to a mid-level manager or supervisor to understand operations from a coordination perspective. Ask them about the gap between what is planned and what actually happens.
- Spend time with at least one frontline worker today. Observe them doing their actual work, and ask questions about their daily experience.

What to focus on in Day 1 conversations

- What does each person consider the most important and most difficult part of their work?
- What are the informal workarounds they have developed because official systems are insufficient?
- Where do mistakes most commonly occur, and what is done when they happen?
- What would the person change first if they had the authority and resources to do it?

Phase 4: Lead and Order Capture Systems

How a business captures and converts customer interest into confirmed work is one of the most revealing areas of process analysis. A large number of businesses lose significant value not in their production or delivery, but in the gap between a customer showing interest and the business formally responding.

What to investigate

- How do customers first contact this business? Through phone calls, walk-ins, social media, referrals, exhibitions, or other channels?
- When an inquiry is received, where is it recorded? Is it written in a register, entered into a spreadsheet, captured in software, or remembered by the person who received the call?
- What happens to an inquiry that does not immediately convert into an order? Is there a system for follow-up, or does that potential customer simply disappear?
- How does the business track the status of an active inquiry — is it being followed up, has it been converted, has it been lost?
- What percentage of inquiries do stakeholders estimate are lost due to missed follow-up or incomplete tracking?

Questions to ask

- Walk me through exactly what happens when a new customer contacts you. Who receives the inquiry? Where is it recorded?
- How do you ensure that no inquiry falls through the cracks?
- Has there ever been a case where you discovered a customer had tried to contact you but never received a response? How did you find out?
- What is the ideal system you would want for managing inquiries and follow-ups?

End of Day 1 — Self-Check

Before you leave the organization today, confirm the following:

- I have traced one complete unit of work from entry to completion and documented each step.
- I have drawn or drafted a basic map of the business's departments and their relationships.
- I have identified the key routine tasks and noted which are system-driven and which are memory-driven.
- I have conducted structured conversations with at least three stakeholders at different levels.
- I have applied the 4-Pillar Standard to at least five areas of the business today.
- I have identified at least two critical vulnerabilities or dependency risks in the organization.
- I have documented the lead and order capture process and identified any gaps.
- I have written down every question I was unable to answer today so I can address it on Day 2.

DAY 2

Deep Investigation, Data, People & Waste

If Day 1 was about understanding the structure of the business, Day 2 is about going deeper into its inner workings. Today you will investigate how information moves, how resources are used, where inefficiencies are hidden, and what the workplace itself reveals about how the organization operates. You will also extend your stakeholder interactions to cover people you have not yet spoken with.

Phase 5: Data, Information Flow and Communication Systems

Information is the nervous system of any business. When information flows well, decisions are made quickly, mistakes are caught early, and coordination is smooth. When information flow is broken — delayed, undocumented, inconsistent, or dependent on individual memory — the business operates in a fog. This phase is about mapping that nervous system.

Data capture and integrity

- Identify every point in the business where data is captured — customer data, order details, inventory levels, financial transactions, employee performance.
- For each data capture point, determine whether data is recorded on paper, in a spreadsheet, in dedicated software, or not recorded at all.
- Identify every point where data is transferred from one system to another — for example, from a paper form to a spreadsheet, or from one software application to another. Each of these transfers is a risk point for error and a candidate for automation.
- Identify cases of data duplication, where the same information is entered in multiple places by different people at different times.
- Assess whether the data being captured is clean, consistent, and structured in a way that could support future use in reports, dashboards, or automated systems.

Communication flow

- How are instructions communicated from management to employees? Is it verbal, written, via messaging applications, or through a formal system?
- How do employees report problems upward? Is there a defined channel, or do issues surface only when they escalate?
- When a mistake occurs, is it documented anywhere so that others can learn from it, or is the knowledge of what happened retained only by the people involved?
- When an experienced employee leaves the organization, what happens to the knowledge they carry? Is it documented and transferable, or is it simply lost?

Issue handling and tracking

- When something goes wrong — a machine breaks, a customer complains, a vendor delivers late — how is it reported? Is it tracked in a system or handled verbally?
- Is there a mechanism to confirm that issues have been resolved? Or do problems sometimes get partially addressed and then forgotten?
- Are issues handled proactively, where the business identifies and fixes problems before they escalate, or reactively, where problems are only addressed after they become emergencies?

Questions to ask

- If I asked you to show me the status of every active order right now, how long would it take to compile that information?
- When a mistake happens, how does the rest of the team find out so they can avoid repeating it?
- Have you ever lost important data — customer details, order history, financial records — due to a system failure? What happened?
- If you had to send a critical piece of information to three people in your organization right now, how would you do it, and how confident would you be that they all received and understood it?

Phase 6: Financial Flows and Vendor Coordination

Financial health is not just about profitability — it is about the operational certainty that comes from knowing when money will arrive, when it must be paid, and whether the business is operating on a solid or precarious foundation. This phase investigates the payment cycle and the external relationships that sustain the business.

Financial processes

- How does the business track payments due from customers? Is there a formal system, or is it managed through memory and informal follow-up?
- How does the business manage payments to vendors and suppliers? Are these tracked systematically to avoid delays or missed obligations?
- Are there situations where payment delays from customers create pressure on the business's ability to pay its own suppliers or employees on time?
- What is the most common source of last-minute financial urgency in this business — the kind of situation where cash flow becomes a crisis?

Vendor and external coordination

- Map the vendor ecosystem: Who are the key suppliers, subcontractors, transporters, and service providers this business depends on?
- How does the business communicate delivery timelines with vendors? Is there a system for tracking whether a vendor will deliver on time, or does the business only find out about delays after the deadline is missed?
- How are vendor performance and reliability assessed? Are vendors selected based on historical data and formal evaluation, or based on personal relationships and habit?
- If a key vendor fails to deliver on time, what is the impact on operations, and how is it managed?

If you can speak with a vendor

Where access permits, speaking directly with a vendor or subcontractor gives you an external perspective that is often more honest than what you will hear internally. Ask them:

- What challenges do you face most often when working with this organization?
- Is there anything about how they communicate requirements or make payments that creates difficulty for you?
- If you could change one thing about how they work with you, what would it be?

Phase 7: Material, Inventory and Resource Utilization

In any business that handles physical materials — whether a manufacturer, a hospital, a retailer, or a caterer — the way materials are stored, tracked, and used is a direct reflection of how well the organization manages its operations. Even in purely service-based businesses, there are resources to track: staff time, equipment availability, and space utilization.

Material and inventory

- Visit the storeroom, warehouse, or production floor. Observe how materials are stored, labelled, and accessed.
- Are materials organized in a way that makes them easy to find and retrieve quickly? Or does finding a specific item require asking someone or searching?
- Is there evidence of materials that have been sitting unused for a long time — dead stock, expired items, or materials for projects that never happened?
- Are there areas where materials regularly run short, causing production to halt or delivery to be delayed?
- Is there a formal system for tracking inventory levels and triggering replenishment, or is purchasing done reactively when stock runs out?

Resource utilization

- Identify the most expensive and most critical resources in the business — machines, specialized staff, licensed software, expensive equipment.
- For each critical resource, assess whether it is being fully utilized, underutilized, or overloaded.
- Are utilization decisions based on data, or on the judgment and experience of individual managers?
- Are there resources that are consistently idle during certain periods and then overloaded during others? What is the cost of that imbalance?

Questions to ask

- Have you ever had a situation where a job had to be stopped or delayed because a material or resource was not available? How often does that happen?
- How do you decide when to reorder materials? Is there a formal trigger or minimum stock level?
- If I walked through your storeroom right now, would I be able to find any item without asking for help?

Phase 8: Waste Analysis and Efficiency Observation

This phase is the most observational of the entire visit. Put away your questions for a while and simply watch. Select one core process in the business — ideally a process that is central to how value is created or delivered — and observe it continuously for at least thirty to sixty minutes.

What you are looking for

As you observe, separate every action into two categories. Value-added activities are those that directly transform the material, product, or service into something the customer is paying for. Non-value-added activities are everything else — waiting, searching, correcting, transporting, re-entering data, asking for approvals, walking across the room to fetch a tool.

You must identify a minimum of ten non-value-added activities during your observation. This is not a difficult target if you observe carefully. In most businesses, non-value-added activities account for more time than value-added ones.

Types of waste to look for

- Waiting — people or materials sitting idle because the next step is not ready.

- Unnecessary movement — people walking to fetch tools, documents, or approvals that could be located closer.
- Rework — activities being repeated because they were not done correctly the first time.
- Overprocessing — doing more work than the customer actually needs or values.
- Data duplication — the same information being recorded in multiple places by different people.
- Searching — time spent looking for materials, files, information, or approvals.
- Interruptions — work being stopped mid-task to deal with urgent queries or problems that could have been anticipated.
- Underutilized talent — people performing tasks that do not match their skills or capability.

After the observation

Once you have completed your observation, share your findings with the person you were observing. Do not present them as criticisms. Ask the person whether your observations match their own experience. Ask whether these are daily occurrences or exceptions. Ask whether the person has any ideas about what could reduce these inefficiencies. Their response will be one of the most valuable inputs of the entire visit.

Basic time and value stream study

For the process you have been observing, create a simple sequential map of all the steps, noting for each step the approximate time it takes and whether it is value-added or non-value-added. Estimate the total value-added time and compare it to the total time the unit spends in the process from start to finish. The ratio between these two numbers is one of the most powerful measures of process efficiency.

Phase 9: Workplace, Safety and Physical Environment

The physical environment of a workplace reveals a great deal about how the organization is managed. A well-organized, safe, and ergonomically sensible workspace reflects an organization that pays attention to detail. A disorganized, hazardous, or poorly laid-out workspace often reflects deeper organizational issues.

Safety observation

- Walk through the entire facility with safety as your primary lens. Identify any areas where there is a risk of physical harm — falling objects, exposed electrical equipment, slippery surfaces, overcrowded storage.
- Ask whether any accidents or near-misses have occurred in the past year. How were they handled? What was changed as a result?

- Are safety protocols documented and visible, or do they exist only as informal awareness?

Workplace organization

- Evaluate the workplace using the five principles of good organization: every item has a defined place, items are stored where they are most needed, the workspace is kept clean and maintained, labelling is clear and consistent, and these standards are upheld as a discipline rather than a one-time effort.
- Identify areas where poor organization creates delays, confusion, or risk.

Floor layout and space utilization

Draw a basic floor layout of the workspace. You do not need to be an architect — a rough sketch with dimensions and labels is sufficient. Use this layout to identify whether the physical arrangement of the workspace supports or hinders the flow of work. Are materials stored near where they are used? Is the sequence of workstations logical? Are there unnecessary distances between connected activities?

Energy and ergonomics

- Identify areas of visible energy waste — machines left running when not in use, excessive lighting in empty areas, poorly insulated spaces.
- Observe the physical posture of employees during their work. Identify any positions or repetitive movements that are likely to cause fatigue or strain over time.
- Based on your observation, suggest at least three specific ergonomic or environmental improvements that could reduce fatigue, improve safety, or reduce energy consumption.

End of Day 2 — Self-Check

Before you leave the organization today, confirm the following:

- I have mapped how data is captured, moved, and stored across the key processes I observed.
- I have identified at least three specific points where data transfer creates risk of error or loss.
- I have investigated the financial flow and identified any pressure points in payment cycles.
- I have assessed vendor and material management, and identified gaps in tracking or follow-up.
- I have completed a sustained observation of at least one core process and identified a minimum of ten non-value-added activities.
- I have drawn a basic floor layout and noted at least two spatial inefficiencies.

- I have conducted a safety walkthrough and documented any risks.
- I have spoken with at least two stakeholders I had not yet interviewed on Day 1.
- I have recorded at least one 'hidden workaround' — an unofficial step a stakeholder takes because the official system is insufficient.
- I have noted at least five improvement ideas that stakeholders already have but have not been able to implement.

DAY 3

Validation, Management Visibility & Synthesis

Day 3 is the most analytically demanding day of the visit. By now you have observations, notes, and a developing sense of where the real problems in this business are. Today you move from observation to analysis. You will validate your findings with stakeholders, investigate how management sees and runs the business from above, examine the customer experience, and finally synthesize everything into a coherent diagnosis.

Phase 10: Management Visibility and Decision-Making

One of the most important questions you can answer about any business is this: does the person running it actually know what is happening inside it? The quality of management decision-making is entirely dependent on the quality of the information available to those making the decisions. This phase investigates that relationship.

What data does management actually have?

- What key performance indicators does the owner or senior management monitor? How are these tracked and how frequently are they reviewed?
- Is performance data available in real time, or does someone have to compile a report before management can see it?
- How long does it take to answer the question: 'What is our current outstanding receivable from customers?' Can that be answered immediately, or does it require time to compile?
- Are decisions in this business typically based on structured data and defined metrics, or on the experience and intuition of the decision-maker?

What data is missing?

- What data does the owner wish they had available immediately that they currently cannot access?
- What data is being collected but never actually used to make decisions? Where is it stored and why has it not been acted upon?
- Are there areas of the business where the owner has a sense that something is wrong, but lacks the data to confirm or quantify it?

Planning systems

- Does the organization have a formal daily, weekly, and monthly planning process? What does it look like in practice?
- Identify at least ten areas of uncertainty that arise regularly in this business because of insufficient or delayed planning.
- How does the business respond when actual performance diverges from what was planned?

Scalability

Ask the owner: if customer demand doubled tomorrow, what would break first? This single question often reveals the most important constraint in the business — the bottleneck that limits growth. Follow up by asking what investment or change would be required to remove that constraint, and what has prevented that investment from being made.

Phase 11: Customer Experience and External Feedback

The ultimate test of any business process is what the customer experiences. Internally, a process may appear efficient. But if the customer has to make repeated phone calls to find out the status of their order, or if errors discovered by the customer reveal problems that should have been caught internally, then the process is not as healthy as it looks from inside.

How to investigate customer experience

- Ask management and frontline staff to describe the most common complaints or concerns they hear from customers. How frequently do these occur? What is the standard response?
- Identify points in the process where customers are most likely to have to follow up with the business — asking for updates, chasing confirmations, or correcting errors. These follow-up moments are always symptoms of process failure.
- Ask whether there is a formal mechanism for collecting customer feedback, and whether that feedback actually influences how the business changes its processes.

If you can speak with a customer

Direct customer interaction, even a brief conversation, gives you a perspective that is impossible to replicate through internal interviews. Ask them:

- What is your experience of working with this business compared to others you deal with in the same area?
- Is there anything about how they communicate with you, or how they handle your orders, that you find frustrating or unnecessarily complicated?

- What would make you more confident, or more comfortable, in doing business with them?

Phase 12: IT Systems, Data Safety and Digital Infrastructure

This phase evaluates the technological foundation of the business — not to recommend specific software, but to understand how digital tools are supporting or limiting the organization, and where the greatest risks and opportunities lie.

Current IT infrastructure

- What software systems does the business use? List every tool — accounting software, inventory systems, communication platforms, customer management tools, and any others.
- Are these systems integrated with one another, so that data entered in one system flows automatically to another? Or do they operate in silos, requiring manual re-entry of data?
- Where is data stored? On local computers, on a shared server, or in cloud-based systems? What is the risk profile of each?

Data safety and recovery

- What is the backup protocol for critical business data? How frequently are backups taken, and where are they stored?
- Has the business ever experienced a data loss event? What happened, and what was the impact?
- If the primary computer or server in the business failed completely today, how long would it take to restore operations, and what data might be permanently lost?

Automation and AI opportunity identification

Based on everything you have observed across the visit, begin to identify the areas with the highest potential for technological improvement. Consider:

- Which manual data entry points could be eliminated through system integration or automated capture?
- Which communication or follow-up tasks are currently done by humans but could be triggered automatically by a system event?
- Which decisions currently made by intuition or experience could be supported by structured data and simple analytical tools?
- What would a basic dashboard look like for this business — what five or six numbers would give the owner real-time visibility into the health of their operations?

Phase 13: Validation and Closing Conversations

The final phase of the visit is as important as any of the investigative phases. You have spent two or more days forming observations and hypotheses about how this business works and where its problems are. Before you leave, you must validate the most important of those observations with the stakeholders themselves.

Why validation matters

What you observe from the outside may not always match the reality as understood by the people inside. A process that looks inefficient to you may have a reason behind it that you are not aware of. A problem that appears severe may already be on the owner's priority list. An opportunity you have identified may have already been attempted and abandoned. Validation ensures that your analysis is grounded in reality rather than assumption.

How to conduct validation conversations

- Share your most significant observations with the relevant stakeholders and ask whether your understanding is accurate.
- Present your identified problems not as criticisms but as questions: 'I noticed that data seems to be entered in multiple places — is that a challenge for the team?'
- For every major finding, ask whether the stakeholder agrees with the assessment, and whether there is context you may have missed.
- Present two or three of your improvement ideas and ask for the stakeholder's reaction. Are they feasible? Have they been tried before? What would make them work in this specific context?

Closing interview with the owner

Your final conversation should be with the owner or the most senior person you have been engaging with. This conversation has two purposes. The first is to validate your overall diagnosis of the business. The second is to ensure that the owner has gained something of value from your presence — that your questions and observations have given them a new perspective on their own business.

- Share your top three findings and ask for the owner's response.
- Ask whether any of your questions during the visit prompted them to think about something in a new way.
- Ask what they believe would be the single highest-impact improvement for their business if implemented well.
- Thank them genuinely — the access they have given you is valuable, and the relationship you have built is one worth maintaining.

End of Day 3 — Self-Check

Before you leave the organization for the final time, confirm the following:

- I have investigated management visibility — I know what data the owner has and what they wish they had.
- I have identified at least ten planning uncertainties that arise due to lack of structured information.
- I have assessed the customer experience, including specific pain points and follow-up patterns.
- I have evaluated the IT infrastructure, identified integration gaps, and assessed data safety.
- I have identified at least three specific automation or technology opportunities.
- I have validated my key findings with stakeholders and corrected any misunderstandings.
- I have conducted a closing interview with the owner and captured their own priorities.
- I have reviewed my notes from all three days and identified any gaps that need to be filled before I submit my report.
- I have applied the 4-Pillar Standard consistently across all major areas of my investigation.
- I can now clearly answer: 'If I were the owner, what are the three most important changes I would make — and how would I implement them?'

After the Visit: Preparing Your Report and Presentation

The visit is complete, but the work is not. Everything you have collected — your observations, your stakeholder insights, your waste analysis, your process maps, your floor layout, your conversations — must now be synthesized into a coherent analysis that a business owner or executive would find genuinely useful.

The Presentation Structure

Your final presentation must be organized around five specific sections. The goal is not to read back your raw notes. The goal is to demonstrate that you have understood this business deeply enough to diagnose its most important problems and propose solutions that are realistic, specific, and implementable.

Section 1: The Executive Diagnosis

Open with a clear, precise description of what this business does, who its primary customer is, and how it generates revenue — in three sentences or fewer. Follow this with your single most important finding: the one insight that best characterizes the health of this business. This should be specific and based on evidence, not a general comment.

Section 2: The Operational Reality

Present your findings on how the business actually operates versus how it is assumed to operate. Show where systems exist and where habit substitutes for systems. Identify the key vulnerability — the single greatest point of failure you discovered.

Section 3: The Three Critical Problems

From everything you observed and documented, identify the three most important or most expensive problems in this business. For each one, present all four pillars: the friction experienced, the root cause, the unimplemented idea, and the barrier that has prevented a solution. Trace each problem back to its origin rather than stopping at the surface symptom.

Section 4: The Business Impact

Translate the inefficiencies you observed into business consequences. How much time is wasted daily on non-value-added activities? How do these internal problems affect the customer

experience or the financial cycle? Where are the safety or ergonomic risks that represent both human cost and operational liability?

Section 5: The Engineered Future State

Propose your solutions. Each solution must be specific and must directly address the barrier you identified — not just the problem. If the business has limited budget, propose a low-cost or free solution. If the owner is resistant to complex technology, propose a simple and intuitive change. Defend your proposals. A weak solution that can actually be implemented is more valuable than a brilliant solution that cannot.

A Final Note on What This Exercise Is Building In You

By the time you have visited four different organizations and applied this framework each time, something important will have happened to how you think.

You will begin to see patterns — problems that appear in every business regardless of industry. You will develop an instinct for where the hidden costs are, where the dependencies lie, and where technology can genuinely help rather than simply adding complexity.

You will also develop something that cannot be taught in a classroom: the ability to walk into an unfamiliar business, earn the trust of the people inside it, understand it completely, and offer something of real value. That is the capability this programme exists to build.